

Printing

Woodblock printing

Where China

When 7th century CE

The Chinese first used woodblock printing to print on paper during the Tang era (see pp.68–69). Wooden blocks were carved with images or words and then ink was applied. A print was made by brushing thin paper onto the block. In the 11th century, Chinese artisan Bi Sheng created moving type by carving letters onto clay. After being baked hard, they were then arranged on an iron frame and pressed against an iron plate.



Details from a page from the Buddhist Diamond Sutra from 868 CE, the earliest-known printed manuscript

1450–1750

Movable type

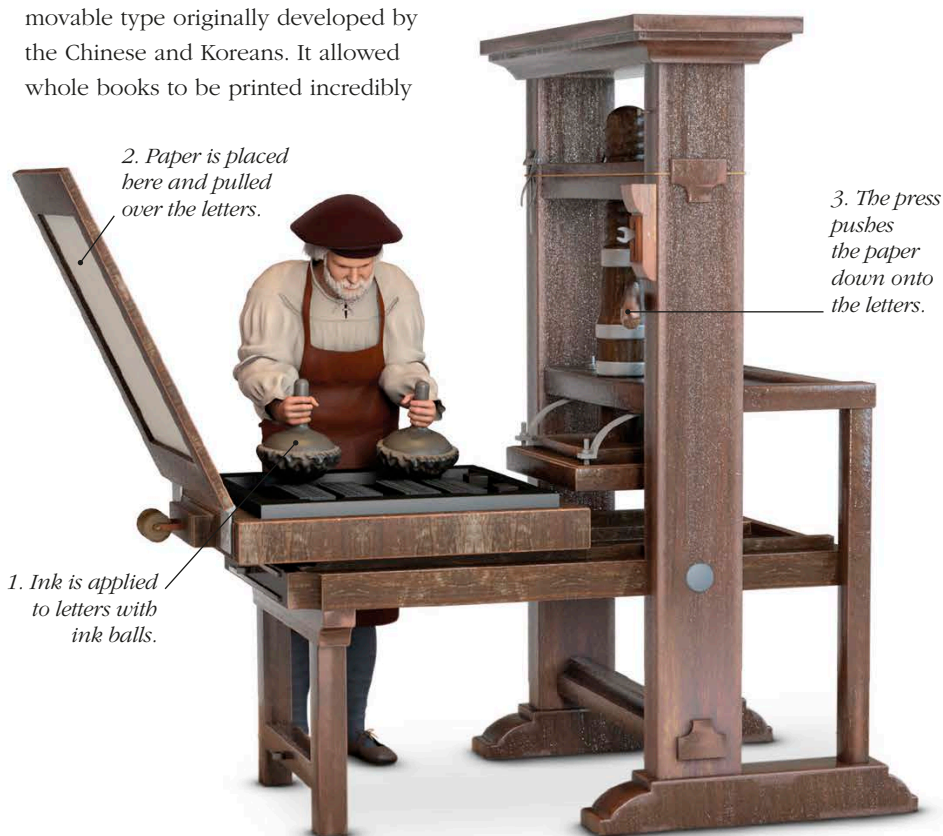
Printing press

Where Germany

When 1450

German inventor Johannes Gutenberg's printing press was a huge leap forward for communication. The machine perfected the technique of using movable type originally developed by the Chinese and Koreans. It allowed whole books to be printed incredibly

quickly, compared to scribes writing each one out by hand. The printing press caught on across Europe and its success meant that knowledge and new ideas could be shared far faster than ever before.



Writing machines

Typewriter

Where US

When 1868

The first modern typewriter was created by inventor Christopher Latham Sholes and mechanic Carlos S Glidden. Typewriters were faster than writing things out by hand, and they remained popular for over a century until they were eventually replaced by electronic word processors and computers.

